A Bone Close to My Brain

By Dan Dietz

NOTE: *This is a play written in verse format*
Check event requirements for your tournament before entering in Poetry

A MAN stands beside an easel; he uncaps a marker and draws a big tooth on the paper.

MAN: **(Pg 16-23)** today my brother is a dentist

he knows all about these little bones

huddling tight inside your mouth

incisors, bicuspids, wisdoms way in the back

he knows them all

their shapes and contours

their uses and misuses

the damage they can reasonably take

from impact or decay

my brother is a dentist today

i don't mean he just got certified

i don't mean he opened a practice

i mean that today my brother is a dentist

just like yesterday he was a radiologist

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and last month he was a reporter for the *new york times*

only two things about him stay the same

day in, day out

his address, this tidy little house in new jersey

which we've shared for the nine years

since our parents passed away

and the fact that i am his big brother

no matter what else he erases and remakes

inside his mind

these two facts sit solid and bonehard

within his head

INTRODUCTION

What are the limits of brotherly love? And what do they have to do with the 32 bones huddling tight inside your mouth? Through sparse dialogue and childlike illustrations, a man describes his relationship with his younger brother -- who is both brilliant and mentally ill -- and the heartbreaking decision he has to make.

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MAN: he can't feed himself

he doesn't grasp the need to fuel his body

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he can't bathe himself
left on his own, he'll either starve or stink himself
to death
he doesn't live in his skin, his stomach, his
fingernails
he lives here
in the bulbous gray organ
just above and behind
the roof of his mouth
that's his house
(MAN draws a roof and windows on the tooth,
maybe even a chimney with smoke)

the rest of him
skin, stomach, fingernails
is like a yard *(draws a yard by the house)*
a yard that needs a full-time, round the dock
landscaper
to keep from going to hell
that's me
i tend him
he trusts me

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anyone else comes near the yard
(skin, stomach, fingernails)
he screams, hits, bites
gets arrested, gets bailed out, forgets, etc.
but not me
he would never hurt me

except for today
today he will hurt me
in about ten minutes
he will walk in here
lay me down on this chair
and tear out of my head
a single, white, completely healthy
tooth *(flips to a new sheet, draws a new tooth)*
and i will let him

i can't get used to the way teeth look
strange
spiny
like they belong on the outside
of some prehistoric fish
not sprouting from my face

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maybe i should smile more
but i was always that way
even as a kid
i can't find one picture of me
smiling showing my teeth
always just a twist of the lips
to indicate a grin
gerald always smiled with teeth
he's smiling right now
in the kitchen, sterilizing his instruments
which consist of a penlight
and a pair of pliers

he's brilliant
he learns this stuff in just hours
pores over textbooks
random ones i pick up
from the public library
to keep his house *(draws a roof on the tooth, draws a yard)*
occupied *(draws a happy stick figure waving from the house)*

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he dives into the volumes
(the only medication he'll accept)
and the next time i see him
he's completely reborn
he's memorized it all
he's a dentist
(radiologist, reporter)
and he can't remember a day
when he wasn't a dentist
(radiologist, reporter)

he was reading tolstoy at age eight
studying fractals at eleven
those huge numbers
blooming out infinite all over the place
numbers that want to be pictures
he called them

what does a number do
if it wants to be a picture

he grew into adolescence
his head devouring everything

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like his eyes were mouths
awards, acclaim
the "g" word tossed about
(and i don't mean "gerald")
by people important enough to believe
he was slated to graduate high school
before his sixteenth birthday

then mom and dad died
when our house
got broken into *(draws a hole on the house and an arrow pointing into the hole)*
attempted robbery
became
attempted rape
became

i was away at college
i didn't have to come downstairs
didn't have to try to stop it
try to save
but gerald

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he was fifteen
the same age as the boy
they caught and convicted
after finding his skin cells
beneath my mother's

i moved back home
took a break from school
gerald however refused to take a break
so close to graduation
less than a year
but the things he started saying
and doing

it was like his mind had twisted
to indicate a person *(points to the person waving from the house)*
a person
that wants to be a picture
and he'll erase and try again
until he gets the picture
right

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he's beautiful at night

he sits in his room

soft light

pages blurring by

he was expelled

for tearing open a substitute's blouse

he insisted she was in danger

her beat was irregular

he could hear it across the room

he had to press his stethoscope

to her bare chest to be sure

silly

tragic moments are always

so f***ing silly

like this one

today

(flips to a new sheet, draws a new tooth)

today my little brother

will remove my tooth

which he is convinced

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upon examination with his penlight

is rife with decay

(draws holes on the tooth)

little holes

in a bone close to my brain

he will administer anesthetic

a rag steeped in ether

(which he got from god knows where)

and pluck out my tooth

("pluck" is probably not

the right word)

and smile

believing

he has saved me from danger

i will give him this belief

today

and tomorrow

i will take him to a place

where they will administer

a more sophisticated anesthetic

one which will

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maybe
combined with other treatments
over the course of years
help

tomorrow
i will turn him over to people
who will break into his house
(draws a roof on the tooth, a yard, arrows pointing into the holes in the tooth)
and do their best
as he flails and screams
to clean the damn thing up

i will leave him there
i will erase him and

because i can't i

you wake up one day
and the decay

i can't find myself

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in this picture

i will leave him there
and return here *(turns to a fresh blank page)*
to my house
and gerald
i know
will hold onto my tooth
forever
a bone close to my brain
perhaps it will reside
beneath his pillow
as he sleeps
giving him dreams
of his big brother
crying "don't hate me"

don't hate me

and perhaps
somewhere in the back of my mouth
i will feel the head
of my little brother shift

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in the night

every night

after

tonight.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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